

Bubo scandiacus

Snowy owl



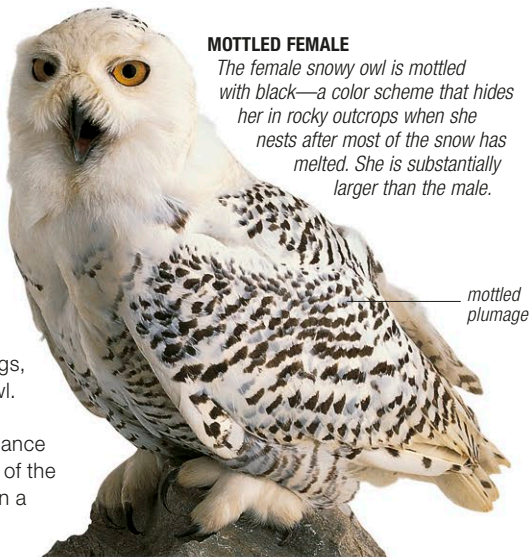
Location Circumpolar around Arctic

Length 22–28 in (55–70 cm)
Weight 2¼–5½ lb (1–2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



With its all-white plumage, the male snowy owl is one of the most distinctive of owls. Long, dense feathers extend right to the toes, and even the bill is largely covered, giving the bird superb insulation against the cold. This owl is

most active at dusk and dawn, but becomes diurnal in summer when daylight is continuous. It spends much of the time on the ground or perching on low rocks, and uses its extraordinary eyesight and hearing to locate distant or snow-covered prey, then ambushes it silently. The snowy owl feeds on lemmings, rabbits, hares, and waterfowl. In fact, its breeding cycle is directly related to the abundance of lemmings: the population of the latter tends to rise and fall on a 3- to 4-year cycle, and the snowy owl follows suit.



MOTTLED FEMALE
The female snowy owl is mottled with black—a color scheme that hides her in rocky outcrops when she nests after most of the snow has melted. She is substantially larger than the male.

mottled plumage

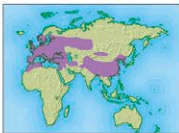
ON THE GROUND



The snowy owl nests on the tundra, forming only a slight hollow in the ground in which the eggs are laid. The female tends the young, feeding them with food brought by the male.

Strix aluco

Tawny owl



Location Europe, Asia, N.W. Africa

Length 14½–15½ in (37–39 cm)
Weight 6–20 oz (1450–550 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



The tawny owl is found in a broad range of habitats, wherever there is sufficient tree cover to provide a daytime roost. Its usually chestnut-brown plumage is heavily streaked and mottled, providing excellent camouflage among branches and leaves. It has a wide variety of calls, among which the best known is the “twit twoo” call produced during the breeding season. This owl hunts from a perch, and can locate its prey—mainly small mammals, birds, reptiles, and insects—by sound alone.



Glaucidium perlatum

Pearl-spotted owllet



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 6½–8 in (17–20 cm)
Weight 1¾–5 oz (50–150 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This compact bird is Africa’s most diurnal owl, hunting at almost any time of the day or night. Its powerful feet enable it to catch prey even larger than itself. On the back of its head are 2 black patches ringed with white. These “false eyes” serve either to deter predators that might attack from behind, or confuse prey so that they do not know which way to flee.

Ninox novaeseelandiae

Morepork



Location Australia (including Tasmania), S. New Guinea, S.E. Asia

Length 2–14 in (130–35 cm)
Weight 5–6 oz (150–175 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



There are several races of this small, stocky owl found in Australia and Asia. One form, found in Queensland, is dark brown, while the form found in

Tasmania and New Zealand, and sometimes considered a separate species, is lighter, with contrasting spots. All have a high-pitched, 2-syllable “boobook” call. Wherever it lives, the morepork (also called the boobook owl) roosts in trees during the day, emerging at dusk to feed. It specializes in hunting insects and birds in midair.



Asio flammeus

Short-eared owl



Location North America, W. and S. South America, Europe, Asia, Africa

Length 14½ in (37 cm)
Weight 7–18 oz (200–500 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



With its long wings and low, flapping flight, this heavily mottled owl can easily be mistaken for a hawk. Usually a solitary bird, it normally roosts on the ground, but in winter, particularly when it snows, it will perch in groups in trees. Groups can also be seen when food is scarce, as large numbers move to richer areas, or when there is an abundance of food in one particular place. This owl finds its prey—mostly small mammals such as mice and voles, and at times birds—mostly by flying, and then pouncing from midair. It lays its eggs in heather, grass, or crops, digging a hollow to hold them safely; unusually for an owl, the female may build a nest from sticks that are lying nearby. It is a fairly quiet owl, with a low, gentle hooting call.

IN BROAD DAYLIGHT



In many parts of its vast range, the short-eared owl—one of the most diurnal of owls—is often seen hunting by day, flying just a few yards above the ground.

Its flight is butterflylike, its large wings allowing it to fly slowly without stalling.

ROUND FACED
The short-eared owl has a large, rounded head with a marked facial disk, bright yellow eyes, and 2 short, feathery tufts that look like ears.



Athene cunicularia

Burrowing owl



Location North, Central, and South America, Caribbean

Length 7½–10 in (19–25 cm)
Weight 4–9 oz (125–250 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



Most owls roost and nest in trees, but the burrowing owl makes its home underground—an adaptation that allows it to live in all kinds of open, treeless

areas, from South American pampas to airports and golf courses. When on guard outside the burrow, it adopts a very upright stance and gives a harsh, rattling call, thought to imitate a rattlesnake. It spends much of its time hunting on the ground.

